

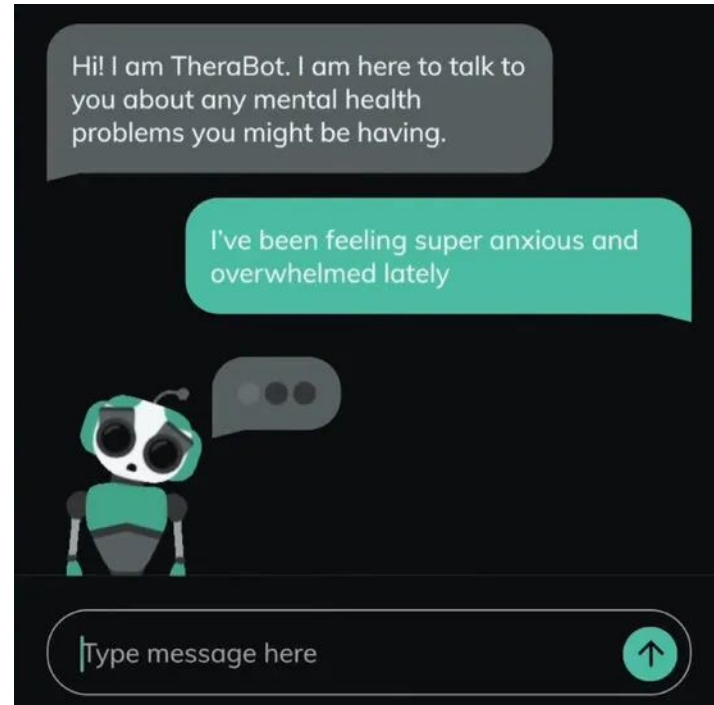
Christian Limitations on AI Counseling

Anthony Rose, PhD

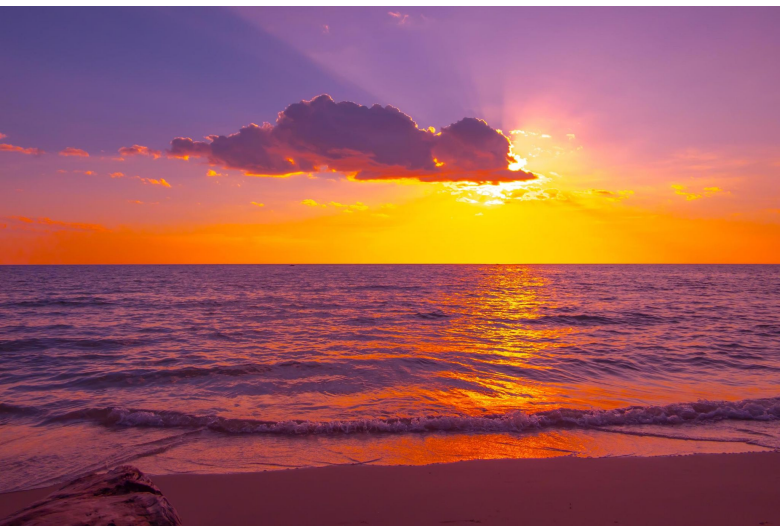


The Current Situation: Assuaging concerns?

- + People are using AI for purposes of psychotherapy: advice, empathy, etc.
- + How should we view it as Christians?
- + Chatbots might be genuinely helpful
 - + There is some (limited) data to suggest it is more helpful than no therapy
- + Still, why does AI psychotherapy not “feel right”?
Prejudice? E.g., radio, TV, etc.



Limitations of AI psychotherapy



- + Research suggests that (all things being equal) we do not get as much out of virtual experiences/interactions as in-person, e.g., books, sunsets, online friends
 - + True even of Gen Z
- + Therapists and clients indicate preference for in-person therapy: qualitative difference.
 - + *Why?*

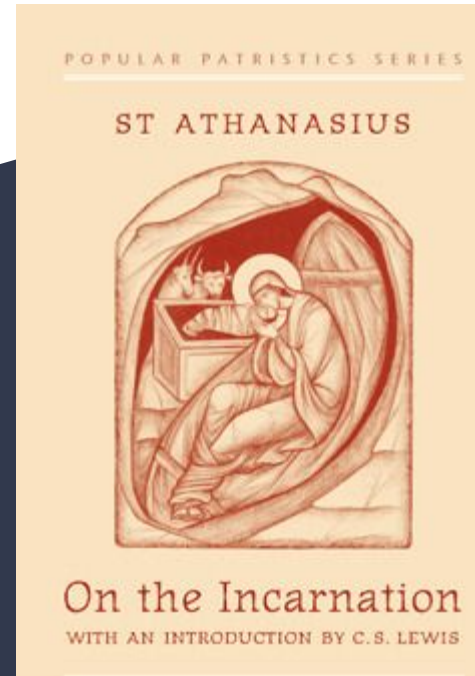
Christian views: Embodiment and Empathy

- + We are embodied: physical beings with a body
- + We have physical needs that cannot be met by the “virtual”
 - + E.g., hunger, sleep, exercise, time in nature, emotions
 - + A virtual plate of food cannot satiate, nor can a virtual relationship
 - + Psychotherapy (et al.) has to be in-person
- + A chatbot is a disembodied “mind”
 - + Expressions of empathy from chatbots will be limited in their visceral, emotional impact (research bears this out): why telehealth (with a human) is still helpful

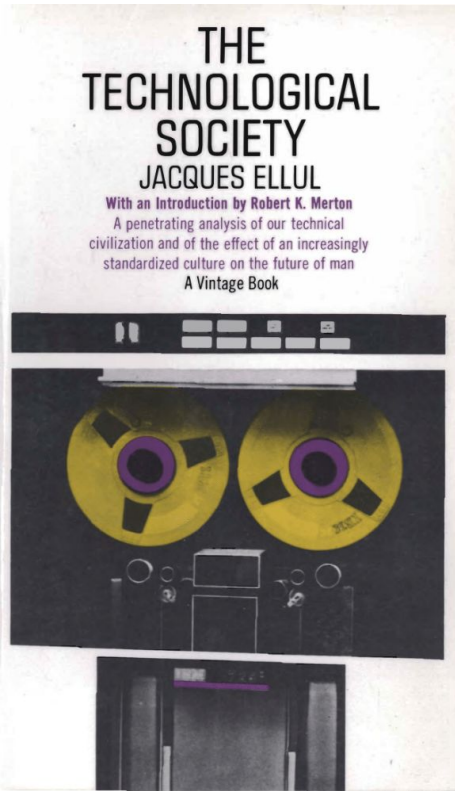


- + “Forasmuch then as the children are partakers of flesh and blood, he also himself likewise took part of the same” - Hebrews 2:14
- + “For in that he himself hath suffered being tempted, he is able to succour them that are tempted” - Hebrews 2:18
- + Jesus: man and God, our mediator
- + Disembodied empathy is not real empathy, from a Christian worldview

The Incarnation and Empathy



The Appeal of Chatbots?



- + Ostensibly low stakes, anonymous means to talk about difficult things, express vulnerability, without “burdening” others
 - + However, we are called to bear one another’s burdens
- + Use of chatbots displaces service and gratitude that might otherwise come from and go to an image-bearer acting out God’s command to love one another: counterfeit
 - + We’re not simply technical machines aiming for efficiency regarding mental health (Ellul)

Other Concerns with Chatbots

- + Programmed Sycophancy: AI Psychosis
- + Should they “behave” like humans??
 - + E.g., thanking your car?
 - + May not be optimal for people with mental health issues?
- + In conclusion: some benefits, but some inherent limitations

